

VALUING INTERNAL COMMUNICATION

**How internal communication
provides value to organisations,
employees and society**

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**The perceived
value of internal
communication
is seen as a
challenge by
practitioners**

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INTRODUCTION

This report is the first phase of a major research project exploring the value of internal communication.

It is being conducted by the Internal Communication Research Hub (ICRH) Europe.

ICRH is housed within the University of Florida College of Journalism and Communications and is led by Public Relations Professor Linjuan Rita Men. ICRH Europe was established by Dr Kevin Ruck in December 2024 and its broad objectives are to:

- Share knowledge about academic internal communication (IC) research being conducted in Europe
- Provide opportunities for European academics and practitioners to collaborate on research that addresses topical challenges
- Promote the benefits of adopting a research-informed, employee-centric, approach to practice

The European group has 17 committee members from across Europe (listed at the end of this report) who have guided the selection of this topic for research and who are undertaking various projects within it.

Rationale

Although valuing internal communication has been explored in various ways in the past two decades, the subject remains topical for academics and practitioners. Indeed, it can be argued that *“the value of communication is too often taken for granted and there is a general lack of an overall understanding of value creation in strategic communication”*.¹

The ability to demonstrate value through data was highlighted as one of five top blockers for delivering for the business in a Gallagher Employee Communications Report.² It is also highlighted in a recent Institute of Internal Communication (IoIC) report on the future of the profession which notably concludes that although there is growing recognition of the strategic value of internal communication, perceived value is seen as a *“challenge”* by 52 per cent of practitioners.³

Methodology

The methodology adopted for this report is a review of academic journal articles and industry reports published in Europe since 2010 that incorporated *“internal communication”* and *“value”* in the abstract or executive summary. Sixty articles and reports were identified. AI was then used to generate themes from the full documents for the *“value of internal communication”*. These themes were then sense-checked and further developed through personal reading and reviewing to hone down a framework that is outlined in this report.

This report is not intended to be an academic journal grade literature review. It draws on selected research and reports and provides high level summaries only.

Scope

The report summarises the primary ways that internal communication is currently understood by academics and the profession to provide value. It is broken down into three domains: organisations, employees and society. This reflects the growing understanding of internal communication and the impact it has beyond organisational performance.

It is focused primarily on internal communication as a managed function within organisations. However, this is, of course, not *all* internal communication and other dimensions sometimes referred to as “*informal communication*”⁴ are an emerging topic of investigation that will also be considered in the research programme that follows this report.

Format

The report is intended to be a useful source of information for academics and practitioners, written in an accessible format and underpinned by both academic and industry research and thinking.

It provides a framework and guidance on practice that is generally understood to provide value for organisations, employees and society.

Further research

The report will be used to inform further planned research with practitioners, senior leaders and employees. This will enable more detailed reports to be produced that provide more granular guidance for practice.

About the authors



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He is the editor and co-author of “*Exploring Internal Communication*” published by Routledge and has contributed chapters to leading communication management text books. He is also a member of the Editorial Advisory Board of the Journal of Communication Management.



Jenni Field is an expert in leadership credibility and internal communication.

Author of *Influential Internal Communication*, and *Nobody Believes You*, her work as an international speaker, coach and consultant helps leaders and their organisations become more efficient and more engaging.

After spending 13 years working inside organisations as Head of Internal Communications and Communications Director, Jenni set up the consultancy Redefining Communications to help organisations communicate clearly, lead credibly, and build cultures that thrive.

DEFINING INTERNAL COMMUNICATION

It is beyond the scope of this report to include a detailed review of definitions of internal communication, partly because there are numerous approaches in academia and practice. Internal communication is also a relatively new organisational function and the ways that it is conceptualised is, understandably, constantly evolving.

In general, definitions fall into three broad categories:

- **PROCESSES OF INFORMATION DISSEMINATION** to audiences with communication systems controlled by management
- **INTERACTIONS AND RELATIONSHIPS** at a range of different levels that are connected to motivation and behaviour
- **HUMAN-CENTRED COMMUNICATION** that enables employees to feel that they are involved, connected and purposeful that extends to an impact on society

Although there are notable differences in emphasis of definitions within these categories, there are also many crossovers between them. For example, an “*information dissemination*” definition notes that “*activities include downward, upward and horizontal communication, and can be initiated by any member of the organization*”.⁵ This indicates that internal communication is not simply one-way from managers to employees. It also includes employee voice, which is a key element of the “*interactions and relationships*” category.

In summary, there is a perceptible trend away from understanding practice as information delivery only to a broader sense of communication that is more dialogic.

Key themes for practice

Before exploring the different ways that internal communication provides value, there are some notable points highlighted in the AI generated summaries of articles and reports about practice itself and these are briefly summarised in the following sections.

Strategy and measurement

To demonstrate its value effectively, internal communication needs a clear strategy and robust measurement practices. More data on the impact of internal communication would be an asset for developing it as a strategic function and improving impact measurement and evaluation is a key priority for practitioners.

Becoming more strategic

There is a clear trend and emphasis on moving internal communication from a purely tactical or disseminative activity to a strategic level. Enabling and promoting dialogue, feedback and participation are key goals. However, encouraging employee participation is identified as a major challenge.

Systems and relationships

Internal communication is fundamental to creating and maintaining communication systems and relationships between employers and employees. It adds to organisational effectiveness by improving internal relationships and communication. Building relationships is highlighted as a crucial aspect, as communication practices are linked to social capital.

These points are briefly explored in the following section of the report and can be understood as *enablers* for securing value-oriented outcomes from practice.

Principles for good practice associated with organisational outcomes and impacts

Strategic internal communication planning, measurement and evaluation

A core principle for effective communication management is that it is based on robust planning, measurement and evaluation.

Strategic communication planning books tend to focus primarily on models for external communication.^{7 8} Models in them often outline a general process from situation and audience analysis to communication objectives and KPIs, a narrative and messages, content creation and activities, which can, of course, be applied to internal communications. Other, dedicated, internal communication publications also include approaches to planning and measurement that adopt similar steps.^{9 10 11}

Distinguished Professor Jim Macnamara's Dissected Program Logic Model for communication planning, measurement and evaluation¹² provides a useful general approach that can be adapted for internal communication, as shown in Figure 1.

It is useful as it identifies what practitioners do, what employees do and what happens as a result. It also incorporates terminology from the International Association for the Measurement and Evaluation of Communication (AMEC)'s Integrated Evaluation Framework, such as inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes and impacts.¹³

The example shown in Figure 1 includes generic outputs, outcomes and impacts that are often used for internal communication. These can be the basis for a more detailed approach that is tailored to each organisation's specific corporate objectives and strategy.

The following definition, provided by Professor Linjuan Rita Men, best represents the broad approach taken for this report:

"Overall, the role and function of internal communication can be summarized as informational (to inform), relational (to listen, connect), motivational (to acculturate, inspire, motivate), and behavioral (to engage)".⁶

What practitioners do and produce (planning, producing and distributing content)			What employees do (reception, reaction and response)	What happens (wholly or partly as a result)
INPUTS	ACTIVITIES	OUTPUTS	OUTCOMES	IMPACTS
Situation analysis	Campaign or programme design (narrative)	Newsletters (opens, reads)	Engagement with content (likes, click-throughs, shares, positive comments, event attendance)	Performance - achievement of organisational objectives
Internal communications audit	Content preparation and creation	Articles and posts for digital platforms (views)	Increased awareness	Profit (for commercial organisations)
Baseline data	Event schedules	Videos (views)	Positive changes in attitudes and advocacy	Better change management
Communication objectives	Senior leader support	Townhall events (attendance)	Higher organisational engagement and strategic alignment	Stronger organisational culture
Plan		Listening events (attendance)	Behaviour changes	Lower turnover
				Enhanced reputation

Figure 1. An adaption of Macnamara's Dissected Program Logic Model for Internal Communication

A key element in this model is the extension of measurement from outputs to *outcomes* and *impacts* as this is where the value to organisations, employees and society can be demonstrated.

This requires firmer emphasis on outcome objectives and KPIs in planning and the use of AI and human judgement in setting and assessing outcomes from internal communication practice.

Research conducted by IoIC in 2025 found that 89 per cent of practitioners have internal communication planning as a responsibility and 24 per cent are choosing to do more planning than last year. However, 50 per cent stated that measurement is a “*challenge needing to be addressed*”.¹⁴ This suggests that whilst planning is common place it may be overly focused on output objectives and measures, such as attendance, opens, reads and views.

If internal communication is to deliver value in the ways set out later in this report, then it is important for practitioners to embed outcome and impact objectives and to focus more on these in measurement and evaluation than outputs.

Communicating

Research into internal communication has traditionally focused on channels. Many approaches to measurement from the 1970s were fundamentally about channel satisfaction.^{15 16 17}

Although this remains an important aspect of practice,¹⁸ especially in a digital, AI and hybrid working environment, other dimensions about content, the quality of communication, listening and relationships with line managers and senior managers have been identified as important enablers for organisational outcomes and impacts.^{19 20 21 22}

Whilst timeliness, transparency and clarity are important aspects of quality, there is evidence to suggest that trust in communication (defined as it being open and honest) is a critical factor for employees.²³ When communications are seen to be open and honest, employees show much higher support for their employer's business priorities. Putting too much gloss (or spin) on the information provided (optimism bias) leads to distrust with a perception that information is being hidden from employees or that leaders are disconnected from operational reality.²⁴

Listening and responding

IoC found that 67 per cent of practitioners have "feedback and listening" included in their current role and responsibilities and 37 per cent were asked to do more by their leaders.²⁵ This indicates that listening to employees is now increasingly being understood as a core internal communication practice.

As with communicating, it is *how* listening is managed that is important for organisational outcomes and impacts. Research indicates that it is not enough to provide basic, one-off, opportunities for employees to have a say about what goes on. Effective listening is ongoing, incorporating multiple methods and reporting mechanisms.²⁶

This may require a fundamental rethink around the role of listening to employees and the value it generates. For example, some academics have recently proposed a new *service logic* approach for organisational listening with its focus on value creation as something that is created in a *process*. This can be contrasted with *goods logic* that has associations with a transmission approach to communication.²⁷

37%

of practitioners were asked to do more listening by their leaders

THE VALUE OF INTERNAL COMMUNICATION FOR ORGANISATIONS

Senior leader expectations

Internal communication can sometimes be understood as being a content producer, behaviour driver, facilitator or asset grower.²⁸

Research conducted by the Institute of Internal Communication (IoIC) and Ipsos Karian and Box in 2024²⁹ with six senior leaders from a variety of organisations in the UK that focused on what they need from an internal communication team highlights the following four points (*italics added*):

1. Ensuring our people feel *informed, engaged and empowered*, so they continue to choose to be here
2. Cutting through the noise, to simplify things for our people and *create a common understanding of what we're trying to achieve* – and why it matters
3. Reaching people through effective channels to meet the needs of our varied audiences, and by *amplifying the leadership team's voices and visibility*
4. Helping us *understand – and act on – the views and experiences of people across the organisation – keeping us connected* and helping us make decisions that take into account the reality beyond the boardroom

Although this is a very small sample, points about a *“common understanding”*, *“engagement”*, *“visibility”* and *“listening”* reflect wider research findings and they are reflected in the proposed framework for organisational value that follows in this report.

Research conducted by CIPR Inside (the Chartered Institute of Public Relations group for internal communication)³⁰ highlights a key finding about the way that senior leaders associate internal communication with the vision, goals and aspirations of the organisation, employee engagement and culture.

A quote from one senior leader in the report defines a *“good”* communication department as being *“Intrinsically linked to the strategy of the business, they need to understand what the strategy is, what the key communities are and then what, how and when they need to communicate with those communities”*.

As one leader put it:

If you don't communicate effectively with your people and don't provide a clear and concise message, and let them understand what's going on, you're probably going to have a dysfunctional organisation.

Further research identifies the increasing expectation that CEOs have for chief communication officers (CCOs) to have their ears to the ground, to talk with employees and talk with employee resource groups to hear their points of views. An important part of the CCO's role, in this regard, is ensuring that employees understand the mission and the values of the company and that their understanding of the culture aligns with what management is striving to achieve.³¹

This is a very brief overview of senior leader expectations as there is currently very limited data on what they perceive to be the value of internal communication for organisational outcomes.



Figure 2 lists the terms that were identified through AI analysis of the documents (image created by ChatGPT).

Literature Review

Our review of 60 journal articles and industry reports published in the past decade generated a number of themes related to how internal communication is generally valued by organisations.

From this analysis it is clear that internal communication is associated with a very wide range of organisational activities, outcomes and impacts.

To be clear, internal communication has a partial impact on outcomes and impacts. Other activities in organisations will usually also contribute to them. However, despite what practitioners sometimes assume, it is possible to measure the degrees of associations. For example, the extent to which leadership communication is correlated with organisational engagement (employee engagement is discussed in more detail later in the report).

This requires advanced levels of research design and statistical analysis that is not usually available to practitioners. This is a pressing and immediate challenge if planning, measurement and evaluation is to be improved to demonstrate the value of internal communication.

Further analysis of the terms listed above, supported through further personal reading of research reports, enabled us to consolidate them into five core themes which forms a PACEC framework for the value of internal communication to organisations:

**PERFORMANCE
ALIGNMENT
CULTURE
ENGAGEMENT
CHANGE**

These themes are explored in more depth in the following sections.

Performance

The AI generated synopsis of journal articles and reports found that internal communication is consistently recognised by academics and practitioners as a vital element for organisational success. It is considered a prerequisite for achieving success and is strongly linked to tangible positive outcomes such as higher levels of performance, productivity, service and product quality, innovation, reduced absenteeism, fewer strikes and a reduction in total costs.

It is important to note that some researchers make a distinction between two dimensions of business performance: *hard outcomes* such as profitability, productivity, growth and competitive advantage which are named economic; and *soft or non-economic outcomes* such as customer satisfaction, employee turnover, stakeholder relations and environmental impact.³²

A balanced scorecard is one approach that organisations can use to map and track factors that contribute to successful *business performance* that includes *hard* and *non-economic* outcomes.

The balanced scorecard incorporates four dimensions:

- Internal processes
- Capacity
- Financial stewardship
- Customer/stakeholder satisfaction

In addition to internal processes (which incorporate quality and efficiency) and capacity (which incorporates knowledge and innovation), other broad business performance enablers often cited are: brand building, capabilities, market segments, products and services, resources, value innovation and visionary leadership.³³

Leadership communication is reported by 80 per cent of internal communication practitioners to be an area included in current roles and responsibilities and influencing and advising senior leaders is a key area where practitioners are now asking (and choosing) to do more.³⁴

This reflects a large body of knowledge that has established the important influence that leadership communication (which includes listening and responding) has inside organisations.³⁵

In terms of capacity, knowledge and innovation, the importance of *internal social media platforms* is often highlighted alongside the ways that organisations “*derive a great deal of benefit from sharing and generating knowledge in multidirectional networks that transcend the entire organisation – knowledge about tasks, workflows, products, services, competitors, customers, technology and IT systems; knowledge that enhances the competencies of frontline employees*”.³⁶

Internal communication is also linked to broader positive brand perception and reputation,³⁷ most notably as a result of employees advocating for the organisation³⁸ and through consistent, aligned, messaging. This is especially important in social media posts made about an organisation by an employee as they add credibility to what the organisation itself communicates. When employees trust, feel committed and are satisfied with their company, they are likely to create and distribute favourable messages about their company voluntarily.³⁹

At an internal corporate communication level, the following have all been linked with employee advocacy: openness, transparency, positivity, legitimacy (employee voice), empowerment and recognition.⁴⁰

Increasingly, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) are also linked to improved business performance and long-term sustainability.⁴¹ Employees can be strong advocates for an organisation's sustainability communication, if they are involved or consulted in the process.⁴²

It is worth highlighting that research in the UK suggests that around half of UK workers experience clear communications on organisational goals, business priorities and performance (between 55–57 percent). Employees who are positive on all three points, report an average engagement level of 79 percent - while those who are neutral or negative are much less engaged at 25 percent.⁴³ And employees who are less engaged are less likely to be positive advocates for their organisation.

Internal communication is also linked to broader positive brand perception and reputation

Alignment

The AI generated synopsis of journal articles and reports found that internal communicators are seen as the custodians responsible for translating strategy, company values and priorities so that everyone in the organisation understands what is important and the part they play.

It also stated that a primary goal of internal communication is creating understanding among employees for economic goals, strategies, processes and decisions. It is vital in ensuring employees understand the organisation's culture, vision, goals, and aspirations and communicating the values of the organisation or organisational culture. Creating alignment across the organisation is seen as delivering strategic value and is identified in the AI generated synopsis as the top purpose for internal communication in 2025.

Four core strategic alignment assumptions are often cited:

1. An organisation's purpose
2. The people required to fulfil the purpose
3. The organisation and co-operation of those people
4. The way that those people unite behind the purpose and work with commitment and loyalty.⁴⁴

Much of the research behind strategic alignment emphasises the linkages between business strategy, organisational capability, organisational architecture and management systems.⁴⁵ What is also emphasised is that an organisation's strategy is inextricably linked to purpose and vision.

Alignment is often seen to be important as it enables organisations to be sensitive to customers, productive, resilient, and engaging. Of the four alignment assumptions listed above, internal communication is clearly key to points one and four.

Strategic alignment is the top purpose for practitioners

Indeed, research with internal communication practitioners found that 86 percent of respondents who report into an internal communication department chose *strategic alignment* as their purpose.⁴⁶ Strategic alignment (creating clarity around company purpose and vision) was also cited as the top purpose for internal communication by practitioners in 2025.⁴⁷

Research has consistently found that employees expect to hear about their organisation's strategy directly from their CEO or most senior leader.^{48 49} This is not, therefore, a topic that can be "cascaded" to line managers or supervisors unless they are suitably briefed or confident to make the connection between strategy and local team objectives.

Culture

Organisational culture is a multi-dimensional concept and understood in different ways. For example, organisational behaviour and culture scholar, Professor Edgar Henry Schein⁵⁰ has proposed the following, often cited, definition for culture:

A pattern of basic assumptions, invented, discovered, or developed by a given group, as it learns to cope with its problems of external adaptation and internal investigation.

A key emphasis here is *assumptions* rather than explicit procedures and/or instructions that are held by a group, which could be the whole organisation or departments/sub-groups within it.

An emphasis on *values* and *understandings* is highlighted in Organisational Studies Professor, Mats Alvesson's definition of organisational culture:

*A shared and learned world of experiences, meanings, values and understandings which inform people and which are expressed, reproduced and communicated partly in a symbolic form.*⁵¹

In this definition a symbol is understood as "a word or statement, a kind of action or material phenomenon that stands for something else and/or something more than the object itself". From this perspective, internal communication managers can be conceptualised, to some degree, as "culture makers" through the symbolic work that is produced and disseminated through official channels inside an organisation.

An alternative perspective on culture outlined by Professor Linjuan Rita Men argues that "More and more companies today are striving to develop an emotional culture which emphasizes how employees feel, such as experiencing joy, fun, happiness, and compassionate love at work, compared with the traditional cognitive culture that sets the tone for how employees think and behave at work, such as a customer-focused, innovative, and competitive culture".⁵²

A cognitive culture is used to describe intellectual values, norms, artifacts, and assumptions that serve as a guide for the group to thrive. An emotional culture is described as the shared *affective* values, norms, artifacts, and assumptions that govern which emotions people have and express at work and which ones they are better off suppressing.⁵³

Men suggests that internal communication managers should be the driving force for creating a benign organisational emotional culture and satisfying employees' psychological needs for relatedness to foster positive employee-organisation relationships. For example, the explicit use of the words of "care", "love" and "family" in communication messages underlines a value of compassionate love. Research indicates that nurturing a positive emotional culture is just as important as building a healthy cognitive culture given that emotional culture can directly affect employees' behaviour.⁵⁴

Culture is the wider context for internal communication practice. It can constrain how internal communication functions, for example through overly bureaucratic levels of sign-off for internal briefings. However, by the same token, internal communication can change culture. For example, a fundamental shift from overly jargonistic, corporate language to informal and more human language can be a powerful and transformational force.

Culture and belonging (fostering an inclusive culture where employees feel valued) was cited as the second purpose for internal communication by practitioners in 2025.⁵⁵

Engagement

Although the term employee engagement has been around for more than twenty-five years, it is still understood in many different ways. Employee engagement is multi-dimensional. However, as employee engagement scholar, Professor Alan Saks, explains, it can be broadly separated into two dimensions:

Engagement is specific to the role that an employee is performing and most employees have at least two primary roles – their *work role* and *their role as a member of their organisation* (italics added).⁵⁶

The differentiation between *work engagement* with *organisation engagement* is significant.

Most studies of engagement (and a lot of engagement surveys) tend to focus on work engagement and include characteristics such as rewards and recognition, support, job variety, and work role fit. At this level, most of the relevant day-to-day communication is done by line managers and supervisors.

In contrast, according to Saks, organisation engagement refers to "*Shared perceptions about the energy and involvement willingly focused by employees toward the achievement of organisational goals*".⁵⁷

Or as internal communication and employee engagement scholar, Mary Welch defines it: *A dynamic, changeable psychological state which links employees to their organisations, manifest in employee role performances expressed physically, cognitively and emotionally, and influenced by organisation level internal communication.*

Applying a more sophisticated understanding of employee engagement has consequences for internal communication. Communication for work engagement hinges on line managers and supervisors who can communicate effectively at an individual employee and team level, providing local level information and listening to concerns or suggestions about local, team level, operations.

Internal communication as it is mostly practiced today is grounded in delivery of corporate level information which is therefore primarily linked to *organisational engagement*.⁵⁸ For example, the three most-communicated topics consistently reported by internal communicators are:

1. Vision and strategy
2. Values and culture
3. Organisational change⁵⁹

This focus is appropriate and highly beneficial for any organisation – both for the organisation and employees.

Research suggests that internal communication satisfaction positively influences employee engagement.⁶⁰ In particular, strong associations have been found between senior manager communication (including listening) and organisation engagement.^{61 62}

There is now a growing body of scholarly work that underpins the wider benefits of organisation engagement. For example, Professor Alan Saks reports positive associations between organisation engagement and the following:

- Organisational commitment - the attitude that employees have toward their organisation
- Organisational citizenship - behaviours that employees perform to improve effectiveness, including the tendency of employees to be co-operative and helpful
- Job satisfaction – job characteristics, rewards, recognition, perceived support, justice

Saks also notes that *“There is now strong evidence that engagement predicts task and extra-role performance as well as general health and well-being outcomes as well as stress, strain and burnout”*.⁶³

It is also worth noting that research does indicate that organisation engagement is, in some cases, more strongly related to a broad range of beneficial outcomes than work engagement.⁶⁴

This suggests that internal communicators should focus on communication support and coaching for senior leaders and internal communication that is grounded in clarity, openness, honesty, two-way conversations and listening.^{65 66}

At a more general level, research in the UK indicates that *“The higher an employee rates internal communication, the higher their engagement score. The real difference comes when we can make the move from ‘good’ to ‘excellent’, which gives an almost 40pt boost to people’s average Engagement Index score (an average of how motivated and valued employees feel, and whether they would recommend their employer)”*.⁶⁷

In a more recent conceptualisation of engagement, researchers⁶⁸ argue for a *“Shift from viewing engagement as a psychological state to understanding it as a communication phenomenon inherently embedded in relational and interactive processes”* (italics added). They advocate a communication-centered approach which provides a more nuanced understanding of engagement that encourages practitioners to support managers and coworkers in fostering meaningful communicative interactions.

Change

The rate of change inside organisations in recent years is reported by practitioners to be unprecedented and it is clear that organisations do understand the value that internal communication brings to successful change management. For example, behaviour change is cited as the top success indicator that organisations expect from internal communication practitioners.⁶⁹

Organisational agility (supporting the adoption of new behaviours) was cited as the third highest ranking purpose for internal communication by practitioners in 2025.

Change management was cited as the second most important skill and change communication was reported as the top role where practitioners are being asked, and are choosing, to do more in 2025.^{70 71}

Research by the Institute of Internal Communication (IoIC) demonstrates the importance of communicating the topic of change well, with excellent communication resulting in 93 percent positivity towards change amongst employees, with clarity, honesty, and listening being key to better change management.⁷²

In addition to major planned change programme communication, internal communication is also becoming more associated with reducing friction, collaborating across departments, creating alignment and increasing efficiency across the business *in readiness for change*.⁷³

This can be linked to organisational resilience – the ability to recover from large disruptions and crisis. According to the World Economic Forum (WEF) there has been limited discussion of what resilience is, or how to achieve it, and WEF argues that organisations need to ensure that they can overcome the shocks of the next few years.⁷⁴ Communication is sometimes highlighted as important generally for resilience⁷⁵ and some of the research into internal crisis communication (especially in the pre-crisis stages)^{76 77} could be applied to organisational resilience building. However, there is currently limited research on the potential associations between internal communication and organisational resilience.

Unfortunately, although the pandemic raised the profile of internal communication in many organisations, practitioners are now expressing frustration that “*what employees need to know*” is rarely considered in contrast with “*what leaders felt they needed to tell them*”. And often, change communication is not connected.⁷⁸ This is despite a substantial body of knowledge for change management communication that has been established over several decades.⁷⁹

This suggests that organisations may appreciate the value of internal communication for successful resilience and change management, but they are sometimes unsure about how (or unwilling) to embed established good communication theory and practice into effective change management communication. The significant costs often associated with large scale change programmes are not being maximised if internal communication is not fully understood and not established as core part of the process from the outset.

THE PERFORMANCE, ALIGNMENT, CULTURE, ENGAGEMENT AND CHANGE (PACEC) FRAMEWORK

Figure 3 recaps the Performance, Alignment, Culture, Engagement and Change (PACEC) Framework for the ways that internal communication provides value to organisations.

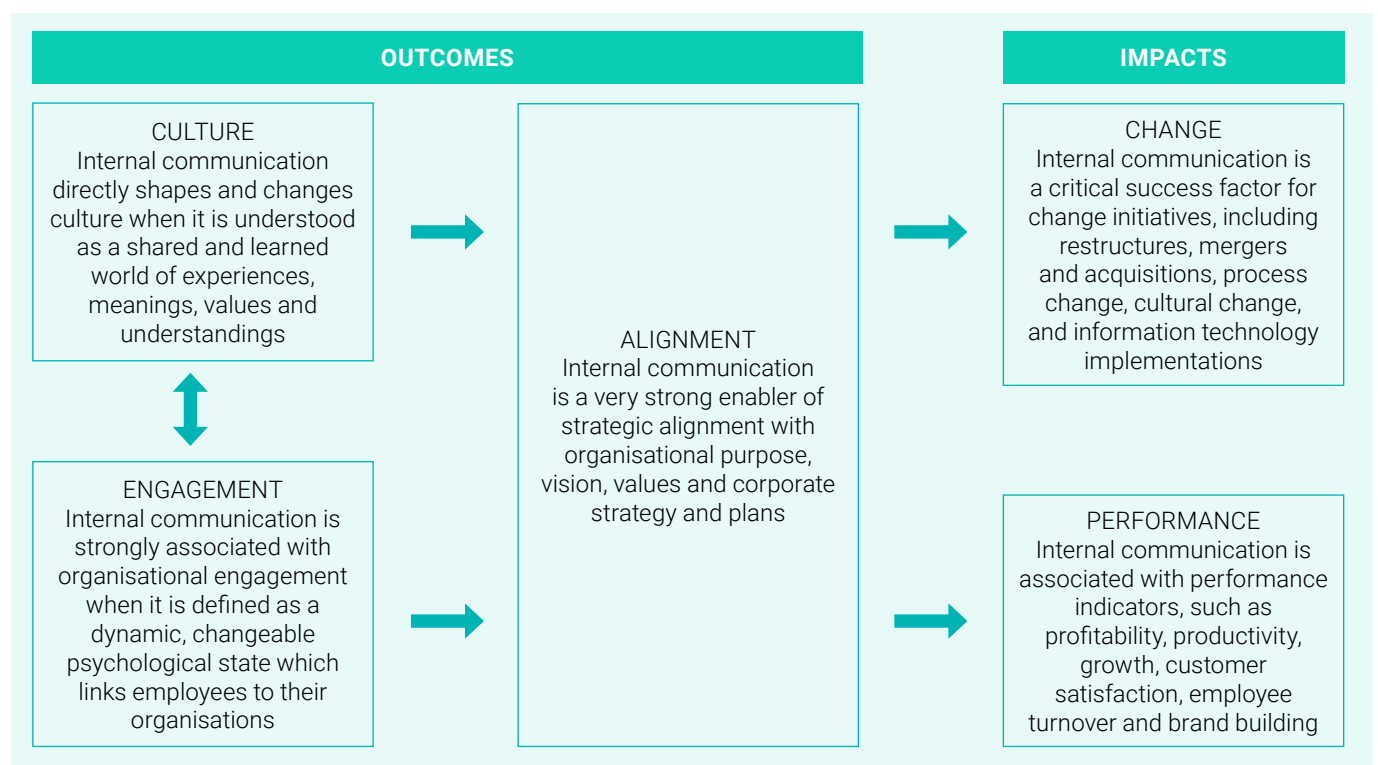
This is a high-level summary only of a vast body of knowledge condensed through our analysis of recent academic journal articles and industry reports.

The framework depicted in Figure 3 suggests that culture and engagement can be considered as broad organisation-wide *outcomes* from good internal communication that support alignment as a separate outcome. The beneficial *impacts* for organisations are more *performance* and *change* related, in terms of an organisation achieving its strategic objectives and specific change programme objectives.

The framework illustrates the wide-ranging impact that internal communication has on organisational life that goes beyond performance. Indeed, it is not surprising to find that internal communication has such an all-encompassing impact on organisations. Indeed, some scholars suggest that internal communication (in all its forms) *constitutes* organisations⁸⁰ and this reinforces points highlighted in the discussion at the start of this report about how internal communication is defined.

However, there is evidence that has been highlighted in this report that strategically planned internal communication is not always fully understood by organisations and practitioners find it challenging (for various reasons) to implement good practice that delivers the potential value to organisations.

Figure 3 The Performance, Alignment, Culture, Engagement and Change (PACEC) Framework for the value of internal communication to organisations



THE VALUE OF INTERNAL COMMUNICATION FOR EMPLOYEES

The relationship that an employee has with an organisation has been the subject of considerable academic research in recent times leading to the development of employee-organisation relationship (EOR) theory.⁸¹ EOR explores how individuals and groups interact with managers and peers and how these interactions impact overall organisational performance and culture. This is linked to social exchange theory which views social life as involving a series of sequential transactions between two or more parties⁸² and feelings of mutual obligation.⁸³

EOR is relevant to internal communication as core concepts within it such as empowerment, the psychological contract and employee engagement are all influenced by internal communication.

EOR can also be understood as an adaption of organisation–public relationship (OPR) theory that has been extensively studied in public relations research.⁸⁴ Much of the thinking within this body of work emphasises *relationships* with external stakeholder groups and EOR reflects this for employees as an important internal stakeholder group.

According to Professor Linjuan Rita Men, “EOR refers to the degree to which an organisation and its employees trust one another (trust), agree on who has the rightful power to influence (control mutuality), experience satisfaction with one another (satisfaction) and commit themselves to the other (commitment)”.⁸⁵

- Trust indicates the extent to which employees feel they can *rely on their organisation*.
- Control mutuality is the extent to which employees feel they exert a similar amount of *control over their interactions* as does the organisation.
- Satisfaction is the extent to which employees are *satisfied with their relationship with their organisation*.
- Commitment is the extent to which employees feel that they are *part of the organisation*.⁸⁶

Communication enablers found to be linked to this definition of EOR include two-way communication, transparent communication, authentic communication and communication channels.⁸⁷

Commitment and feeling part of an organisation is also referred to as *belongingness*. Belonging is *“a practical imperative of socializing inclusive and empathic communities...fostering social cooperation and trust at the societal level”*.⁸⁸ This includes psychological safety at work, defined as *“people feel able to speak up when needed—with relevant ideas, questions, or concerns—without being shut down in a gratuitous way”*.⁸⁹

It is worth noting that there is also a strong recognition that a sense of belonging drives organisational performance. It was reported in 2020 as one of the highest rates of consensus of importance that Deloitte has seen in a decade of its Global Human Capital Trends reports.⁹⁰

The Deloitte report notes significant changes to how people work, with internal communication playing a major role in connecting people to the changing nature of work, helping them to find their role and their space to perform at their best.

When a sense of belongingness is combined with alignment with an organisation’s purpose, values and goals this enables an employee to *identify* with their organisation.

Identification is also dependent on employees feeling valued. Research suggests that employees respond to the way that managers and leaders communicate with them in terms of how important or unimportant they felt in the interaction and this is related to them feeling valued or not. This is most notably the case with senior manager communication and employee voice.⁹¹

Effective internal communication has been found to indirectly strengthen identification by fostering a positive emotional culture in which employees felt comfortable expressing their emotions.⁹² Identification is also related to pride and how far an organisation cares for employees.⁹³

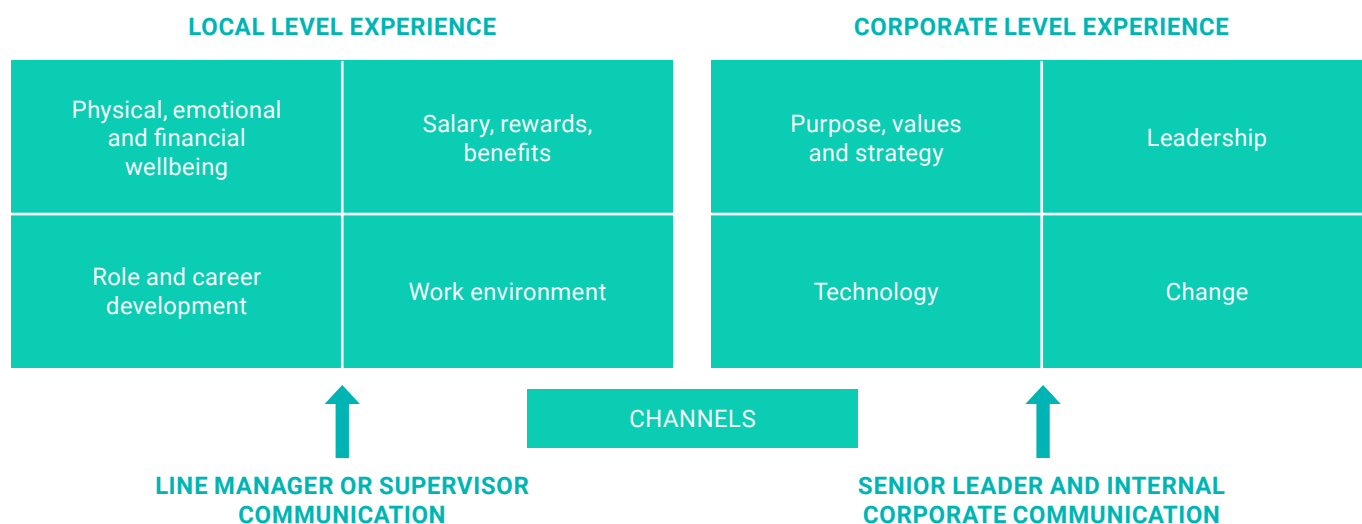


Figure 4 Employee experience dissected into local and corporate level experiences

Identification with an organisation may be of particular concern for gen Z employees (people born between 1997 and 2012) who, unlike previous generations of workers, are prioritising stability in the workplace. They are particularly interested in creating workplaces that align with their values and they demand respect, purpose and the freedom to live a life that does not only revolve around work.⁹⁴

Employee experience is a concept borrowed from consumer and IT domains. It is, in essence, the entire lived experience of an employee which can be affected positively or negatively by multiple factors, both personal and organisational.⁹⁵

It includes a wide range of concepts such as culture plus technology and physical space, meaningful work, positive work environment, belonging, appreciation, community, understanding, and unity. It's about the whole experience of being at work, rather than discrete events. This includes empathy that extends to support for all employees, inclusion, and psychological safety to speak out which permits questioning of expectations.

Figure 4 takes some of the often-cited components for employee experience and segments these into local and corporate level experiences. Although this is not an exact split, it demonstrates how internal communication broadly maps into either a focus on line manager communication or senior leader communication.

Despite some challenges in defining employee experience and varying perspectives on it, there is a growing interest in how internal communication managers can be more involved in developing a positive employee experience.

For example, in the 2021 Gallagher State of the Sector (SoS) report, 58 per cent of respondents named “*broader employee experience themes (recognition, compensation, well-being, diversity and inclusion)*” as one of the skills that internal communication professionals should look at developing in order to continue their influence at organisations.⁹⁶ The focus on employee experience was also highlighted in the 2023 SoS report,⁹⁷ where 36 per cent of respondents cited no digital experience strategy and 33 per cent reported a lack of activity around environmental and social impact.

Employee engagement and a positive employee experience are also associated with employee well-being. When we feel engaged at work, we feel good about work and therefore our psychological well-being is addressed.⁹⁸

Well-being comprises three dimensions:

1. **Psychological - satisfaction, self-respect, agency, and capabilities as they relate to work.**
2. **Social - helping others, becoming involved in the community, and having public acceptance.**
3. **Physical - shelter, healthcare, clothing, mobility and nourishment.**⁹⁹

The World Health Organisation defines mental health as “*a state of well-being in which an individual realises their own abilities, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively, and is able to make a contribution to their community*”.¹⁰⁰ This is a useful framework for understanding overall employee well-being because it highlights the importance of positive mental health attributes that are essential for thriving in the workplace.

Internal communication plays a *functional* role in informing employees about an organisation’s employee financial, health and social initiatives. However, more research is needed to understand the types of well-being messages that employees respond to and how small group and one-to-one meetings may complement company-wide wellness messages.¹⁰¹

Internal communication that is inclusive and accessible through the wide availability of channels, events and meetings for *all employees* and the language and tone of voice used is also an important part of reducing depersonalisation and the potential negative impact on mental health.^{102 103 104}

At a deeper level, keeping employees informed (in the ways that they expect) and giving them a voice that is treated seriously that leads to a positive *communication climate* also contributes to well-being.^{105 106}

Recent research also highlights the important role that managers have in developing an *appreciative working climate* focusing on:

- Praise and gratitude (e.g. praise, compliments, saying thank you, and positive feedback)
- Trust and responsibility (e.g. expressing trust, asking the employee for advice, honouring competency, assigning interesting tasks or new responsibilities to the employee)
- Support and respect (e.g. emotional support, instrumental support, spending time, listening carefully, respecting my needs, saying sorry)
- Motivated cooperation (e.g. motivated teamwork, joy, good mood in team, finding solutions together)
- Tangible reward and promotion (e.g. getting a present or a bonus, being invited, being promoted)¹⁰⁷

Research has found that “employers can significantly affect employee well-being by focusing on psychological workplace climate and engagement as antecedents”.¹⁰⁸ Engaged employees have been found to show “higher levels of well-being all round, meaning that they are more likely to enjoy their work activities, are able to cope with work-related problems and are less likely to lose sleep over work-related issues”.¹⁰⁹

This illustrates how focusing on internal communication for *organisational engagement* also contributes to employee well-being as well as *performance* related outcomes.

WELL-BEING
(positive communication
climate, satisfaction,
support, agency)

IDENTIFICATION
(alignment of values and purpose,
feeling valued and respected)

BELONGINGNESS
(community, accessibility, inclusion, appreciation,
engagement and experience)

Figure 5 The value of internal communication for employees: belongingness, identification and well-being

THE VALUE OF INTERNAL COMMUNICATION FOR SOCIETY

The third, societal, domain for valuing internal communication is one that, to date, has not featured very prominently in academic or industry research.

The Institute of Internal Communication (IoIC) makes a strong connection to societal impact in its principles statement, where it says that it promotes “*high standards of effective internal communication to benefit business and the wider economy, communities, families and society*”. The institute also states that “*By aligning people with collective goals, internal communication underpins longer-term organisational sustainability*” and there is an implicit economic benefit to society when organisations are sustainable.¹¹⁰

The primary contribution that internal communication makes to society is therefore an economic one. When good internal communication contributes to organisational outcomes and impacts, the organisation is more successful (and profitable) and therefore provides more employment and pays more taxes that support a cohesive society.

There is a further dimension to societal impact. It is an obvious point, but employees are also members of society. The question is how far does their work experience and identity affect their life outside of work in a positive way for families and communities?

One avenue to explore this is *life satisfaction*, which is a function of many separate but interrelated domains such as health, family, community, leisure and *work* (italics added).

We have already highlighted how internal communication is associated with belongingness, identification and well-being and where organisations get this right for employees it has potential positive crossovers into life satisfaction and consequential benefits to society.

Research into internal communication and life satisfaction is very rare. However, a groundbreaking academic study in 2020 found a strong relationship between them. A key finding was that the associations were strongest for *informal communication* and the general *communication climate*.¹¹¹ This suggests that employees who experience good internal communication that includes informal opportunities to build relationships with colleagues will have higher levels of life satisfaction.

Informal communication is an important aspect of internal communication that is not discussed or explored enough by academics and practitioners. Recent research makes an important distinction between *formal* and *informal* dimensions of internal communication, where formal communication is based on an employee’s professional role in an organisation and informal is based more on a personal role (friend or acquaintance). As the researchers point out, most internal communication is a combination of both dimensions.

Four factors for informal internal communication were identified:

INFORMATION AND COORDINATION -

provision of useful information to work effectively, organisation day-to-day activities and social ties that contribute to organisational cohesion

BELONGING AND CONNECTEDNESS – emotional connection with an organisation and its values, beliefs and goals and belonging within teams

STRESS MANAGEMENT AND RECREATION – taking a break from routine, relaxation, entertainment and an outlet for venting frustrations

PRIVATE RELATIONSHIPS – building friendships and acquaintances beyond professional interactions¹²

There are clear echoes of some of the points highlighted in previous sections of this report, such as providing “*useful information*” and the “*connection with an organisation and its values*”. Other aspects point to the wider enablement of a working environment that allows, or promotes, taking breaks and informal friendships at work.

This underlines the ways that internal communication provides a wide range of benefits that go beyond the more obvious, and more discussed, performance-related outcomes. Indeed, limiting the scope of internal communication to performance only outcomes is clearly short-sighted and may, inadvertently, actually detract from performance by under-playing supporting outcomes such as engagement, culture, belongingness, identification and well-being.

Informal communication is an important aspect of internal communication

THE COST OF POOR INTERNAL COMMUNICATION

This report has summarised the value that internal communication provides to organisations, employees and society.

The consequences of a *poor internal communication climate*, where employees are dissatisfied with the channels used, the information provided and the quality of communication and where a lack of opportunity is provided for them to speak out (or where a deaf ear is turned to what is said¹¹³) are far reaching.

Some of the more obvious negative outcomes and impacts are briefly summarised here.

From an organisational perspective, poor communication leads to serious misalignment that directly hits the bottom line. Research indicates that highly aligned organisations increase revenue 58 percent faster and are 72 percent more profitable than those operating in misalignment.¹¹⁴ According to some, misalignment is “*is the silent killer of business growth*”.¹¹⁵

When communication fails, so do campaigns, projects, objectives—and sometimes even companies.

Research in the US has found that employees say miscommunication and communication barriers lead to delays or failures in project completion (44%), missed goals (31%), and lost sales (25%).¹¹⁶

Poor communication is also cited as a primary reason for employee disengagement and silence.¹¹⁷

This can contribute to less discretionary effort, reducing overall team output and a lack of commitment (that often necessitates additional quality control, further straining resources). Disengaged employees are less likely to collaborate or share ideas, stifling innovation and making organisations more vulnerable to competitive threats.¹¹⁸

Costs associated with failed change management can be significant, most notably for budget overruns and, occasionally, projects may be shelved or abandoned entirely, resulting in wasted investments and lost opportunities.¹¹⁹
120 121 122 123

Poor internal communication contributes to low levels of employee advocacy that can affect talent acquisition and recruitment and undermine effective issues management.¹²⁴

It can also lead to employee activism and/or whistleblowing, with consequential impacts on brand and reputation.^{125 126}

It is difficult to put a figure on the financial costs of failure due to poor internal communication, as it is always a partial contributor to both positive and negative outcomes and impacts. However, an estimated US \$26,041 cumulative cost per worker per year has been calculated for productivity losses resulting from communications barriers.¹²⁷ According to research by Grammarly in the US, knowledge workers spend approximately 20 hours a week on written communication and business leaders estimate their teams lose an average of 7.47 hours per week to poor communication.¹²⁸ Other research estimates suggest that knowledge workers spend between 1.8 and 2.5 hours per day searching for information.¹²⁹

From an employee perspective, poor communication (and consequential disengagement) is associated with low levels of trust and higher risks of employee activism.¹³⁰ It is also linked to higher levels of stress, absenteeism and burnout.^{131 132 133}

Although there is no specific research that could be identified relating to the costs of poor internal communication to society, the economic consequences are clear. It would also be reasonable to suggest that the costs of reduced well-being and identification may affect self-esteem and this may well have negative impacts on personal relationships and family life.

THE INTERNAL COMMUNICATION VALUE LADDER

As highlighted at the start of this report, establishing the potential value of managed internal communication is dependent on a strategic plan that is regularly measured and evaluated.

Applying situational research and developing measurable outputs, outcomes and impacts was outlined in Figure 1 through the adoption of Macnamara's Dissected Program Logic Model for Internal Communication.

The potential outcomes and impacts identified in this report will not be secured if managed internal communication is understood simply as sending out messages (SOS).

Figure 6 shows how good and effective internal communication is a combination of information sharing (in the ways that employees expect and which enhances knowledge management)

and listening (and responding). When this is established, organisations develop a *dialogic communication climate* that is associated with engagement, commitment, strategic alignment, trust, advocacy and well-being. This in turn underpins a stronger and healthier culture that is associated with high performance and successful change management.

The ladder embeds *planned, slipped and realised* values as core elements of the planning, measurement and evaluation process that were highlighted recently in a broad evaluation of value formation in strategic communication management.¹³⁴

Incorporating these checks is fundamental to reflection and learning that ensures that internal communication is continually improved in ways that optimise the achievement of outcomes and impacts.

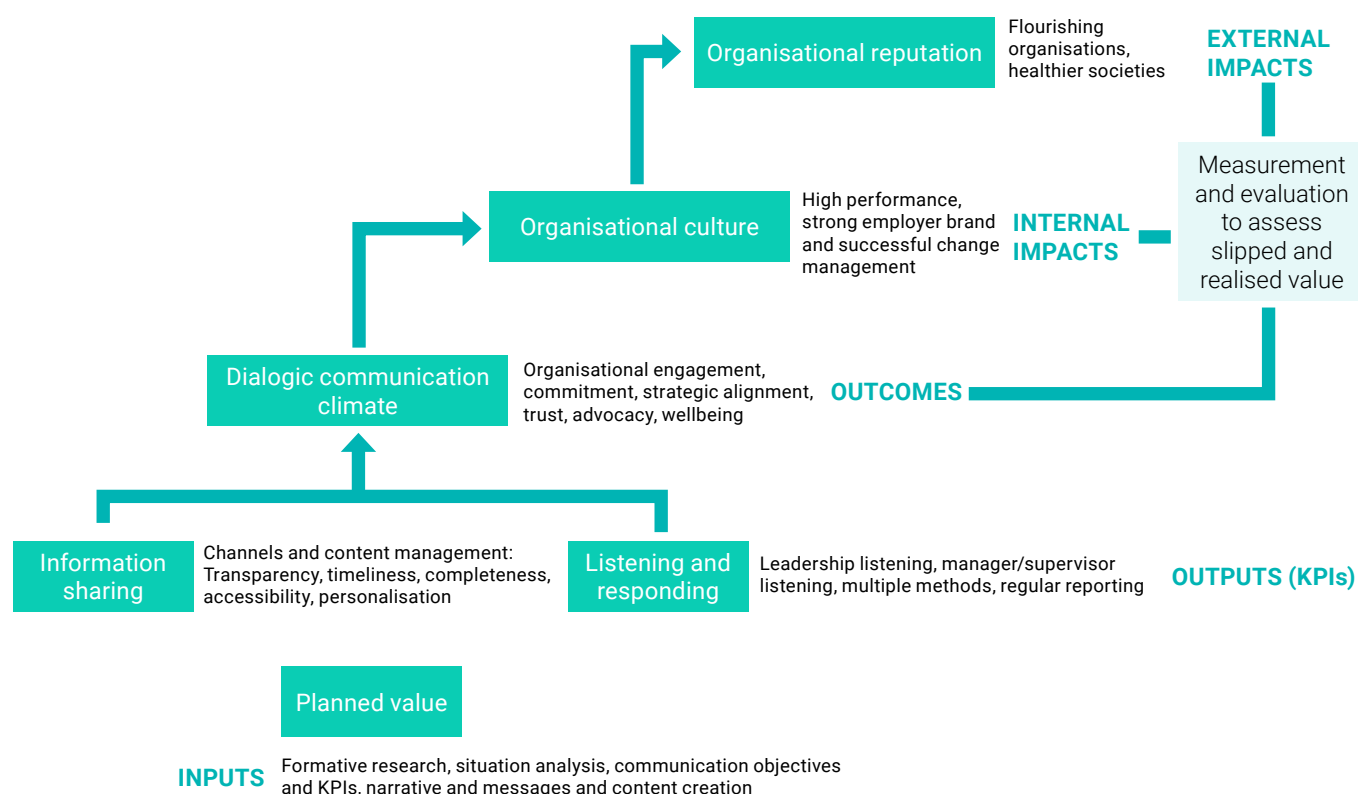


Figure 6 The Internal Communication Value Ladder

THE GENERAL BUSINESS CASE FOR INTERNAL COMMUNICATION

This report has summarised the numerous ways that internal communication provides value for organisations, employees and society.

Although there is a wealth of supporting data that underpins the value that can be secured, this report is an overview only.

That said, it provides an overwhelming general business case for organisations to invest seriously in internal communication.

In terms of resources and team size, cross-data analysis based on organisational size suggests an industry rule of thumb of “one IC professional for every 1,000 employees (1:1000)”.¹³⁵ Many practitioners report having a lack of time/resource,¹³⁶ so this is a useful guide to team-size. However, the number of practitioners based on the size of the organisation is only one consideration and resources may be more dependent on the communication challenge and/or the extent of change within the organisation.

We have highlighted the importance of understanding internal communication from a relationship building perspective at several points in this report. It is worth noting that some academics argue that *“The greatest value of good internal communication are the relationships organisations build, which in turn lead to organisational efficiency”* and *“internal communication strategies, when effectively applied, help organisations create and sustain a higher level of employee engagement, which in turn leads to higher levels of performance”*.¹³⁷

As we have outlined, relationship-building inside organisations and engagement are also associated with other beneficial outcomes, including those for employees and society.

For now, practitioners building business cases for resources for internal communication can start with a situational analysis, applying the PACEC framework for organisational outcomes and the belongingness, identification and well-being framework for employee outcomes (Figures 3 and 5 in this report).

The evidence in this report is not always fully reflected in business leadership education and training¹³⁸ and, from our conversations with clients and students, internal communication is still often seen as a basic function of channel and content management that does not require advanced skills. The relationship between an internal communication team and senior leaders is therefore critical in explaining the potential outcomes and impacts that good internal communication can achieve.

The challenge is to increase awareness and understanding of the value of internal communication. Hopefully this report is the start of that process and further ICRH Europe research will enrich understanding even further.

FURTHER RESEARCH

This report is the first stage of ICRH Europe research into the value of internal communication.

Although research has established clear associations between internal communication and many different organisational outcomes, there is scope to explore how far, and in what ways, value is currently recognised in organisations in practice. This includes further research with senior leaders and internal communication practitioners to explore how well the value outlined in this report is understood and the challenges in implementing strategic internal communication plans based more on outcomes and impacts than outputs.

There is also a strong body of knowledge on the ways that internal communication is associated with a positive employee-organisation relationship and the benefits of employee satisfaction with internal communication. This requires a broader conceptualisation of internal communication that goes beyond performance-related only outcomes. Further research with employees, senior leaders and internal communication practitioners would enable a deeper understanding of employee-oriented expectations from practice and the challenges in meeting them.

Finally, more research on the potential value to society from internal communication (especially informal communication) is required to build a stronger understanding of this emerging dimension of practice. This will be explored with employees, senior leaders and internal communication practitioners.

Research suggests that internal communication satisfaction positively influences employee engagement

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